

Chapter 10: Lines You Don't Cross

Jenny didn't sleep well.

Again.

That was becoming normal.

She lay awake staring at the ceiling, replaying one sentence.

Be careful. Me.

It should have been simple.

A warning.

A warning from a man who thought too highly of himself.

But it didn't feel simple.

It felt... personal.

Jenny turned on her side.

"Ridiculous," she whispered to the dark room.

Morning came too fast.

The restaurant was already alive when she arrived.

Steam.

Noise.

Orders shouted across the kitchen.

Bao was already there.

Of course he was.

He looked up immediately.

"You look like you didn't sleep."

"I slept."

"You're lying."

Jenny tied her apron tighter.

"I'm fine."

Bao leaned closer.

"That's what people say before they collapse."

Jenny walked past him.

"I'm not collapsing."

"Yet."

She ignored him.

She had learned that ignoring Bao was a survival skill.

The lunch rush started early.

Too early.

And like clockwork...

The bell above the entrance rang.

Jenny froze for half a second.

Then continued walking.

She didn't need to look.

She already knew.

Austin Blackwood.

Of course.

But today felt different.

She felt it before she saw him.

The air shifted slightly.

Like the room adjusted itself around his presence.

Jenny approached the table.

"Same as usual?" she asked.

"Yes."

He didn't look up immediately.

That was new.

When he finally did, his eyes scanned her face.

Not casually.

Carefully.

Jenny frowned.

"What?"

"You're tired."

"I heard that already."

"I don't think you're listening."

She crossed her arms.

"I don't think you're my doctor."

A faint pause.

Then—

"No."

"But?"

"I still notice."

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"Stop noticing so much."

That earned a small reaction.

Not a smile.

But something close.

He leaned back slightly.

"You're defensive today."

"I'm working."

"You're avoiding."

Jenny stopped.

That hit too close.

She placed the order pad down harder than necessary.

"Why do you always do that?"

"Do what?"

"Act like you know what's going on in my head."

"I don't."

"Then stop acting like you do."

Austin studied her for a moment.

Longer than usual.

Then he said quietly,

"I don't act."

That silence between them stretched.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

She hated that she didn't have a quick reply.

Because she usually did.

Always.

But not with him.

Not anymore.

Behind them, Bao whispered,

"This is getting intense..."

Jenny shot him a look.

He vanished into the kitchen instantly.

Austin finally spoke again.

"You didn't eat breakfast."

Jenny froze.

"...What?"

"I can tell."

"That's not something you can just—"

"You skipped it."

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You're impossible."

"You're predictable."

That stung more than it should have.

Jenny leaned forward slightly.

"Don't start analyzing me."

"I'm not analyzing."

"Then what is this?"

Austin paused.

For once, he looked unsure.

That was rare.

Then he said,

"I don't know how to stop noticing you."

The words hit the space between them like a dropped glass.

Sharp.

Unavoidable.

Jenny went still.

Not angry.

Not amused.

Just still.

Austin looked away first.

A mistake.

Because now the silence became heavier.

Jenny straightened slowly.

"That's not something you should say," she said quietly.

"I know."

"Then why did you?"

A pause.

"I thought you should hear it."

Jenny blinked.

"That doesn't make it better."

"I didn't say it would."

Her heart was doing something annoying now.

Something fast.

Something she didn't like.

She stepped back.

"Finish your food."

Austin didn't argue.

That was worse.

Because he usually did.

Jenny turned away quickly.

Too quickly.

Work blurred after that.

Orders.

Customers.

Noise.

But everything felt slightly off-center.

Like something had been moved and not put back correctly.

Every time she passed his table, she felt it.

His presence.

Not loud.

Not demanding.

Just there.

Watching.

Waiting.

At one point, Jenny caught herself looking back.

And found him already looking at her.

She turned away immediately.

Too fast.

Bao noticed.

Of course he did.

"Ohhh," he said quietly.

Jenny snapped, "Don't start."

"I didn't say anything."

"You were thinking it loudly."

By late afternoon, the restaurant slowed.

Austin stayed longer than usual.

Again.

Jenny finally walked over.

"You're not leaving?"

"I will."

"When?"

"When I finish this."

He gestured to a document.

Jenny frowned.

"You work everywhere."

"I work where I am."

"That sounds unhealthy."

"It's efficient."

Jenny sighed.

"You're exhausting."

That time, he actually smiled.

Small.

Real.

"You're still here," he said.

"That's my job."

"No," he said calmly. "It isn't."

That made her pause.

"What does that mean?"

Austin closed the document.

Looked at her fully now.

It wasn't intense today.

It was steady.

"I think you know," he said.

Jenny didn't respond.

Because she did.

And that was the problem.

A long silence followed.

Then Austin stood.

"I'll go."

Jenny nodded quickly.

"Good."

He didn't move immediately.

Instead, he looked at her one last time.

Longer than necessary.

Then he said,

"I meant what I said."

Jenny's voice came out softer than she intended.

"I know."

A beat.

Then Austin turned and walked out.

No argument.

No tension.

Just... quiet.

Jenny stood there long after the door closed.

Bao walked up beside her.

"He's gone again."

"I noticed."

Bao tilted his head.

"You look different."

"I'm fine."

"No," he said. "You're not."

Jenny didn't answer.

Because for the first time...

She wasn't sure what she was feeling anymore.

Only that it was starting to feel like something she couldn't control.

And that terrified her more than anything else.